

Spells for the afterlife

In ancient Egyptian belief, the *ba* (the element of the soul that contained the personality of the deceased) faced a series of trials on its journey to the underworld. Failing these trials would mean a second death—obliterating earthly memory of the deceased, who would wander as a ghost forever. To avoid this second death, the Egyptians covered the walls of their tombs with The Book of the Dead, texts containing spells for the soul's protection. The scene here shows the *ba* (in white) accompanied by jackal-headed Anubis, who watches the soul's sins being weighed against a feather. If the sins are heavier, the *ba* will be devoured by Ammit, a crocodile-headed demon.

The Book of the Dead was never codified and no two copies are the same. Each was composed at a patron's request, incorporating prayers that best reflected the individual in order to help them in the afterlife. Composition of Books of the Dead began around 1700 BCE, replacing earlier texts. Spells were added until a body of around 200 became common by about 1500 BCE. Contained in scrolls up to 22 yd (20 m) in length for commoners, or for royalty painted on tomb walls, the spells were said to be spoken by the *ba* at key points along its journey. Spell 4 is to let the *ba* turn into a snake, Spell 89 to return to the tomb at night, and Spell 98 to grant it passage on a ferry to the underworld. So powerful was ancient Egyptian belief in their efficacy that the scrolls were popular until the Roman conquest in 30 BCE.

“I am noble, I am a spirit ...
Oh all you gods and all you
spirits, prepare a path for me.”

SPELL 9, BOOK OF THE DEAD

